

The normal extension service covers the whole country. It is a central

These various methods are applied in two ways: first, in "normal" or specialised scheme areas by Ministry of Agriculture personnel and, second, in development schemes by staff recruited through the Ministry and then posted to consider the two approaches separately.

The mobile units in Malawi are Land Rover station wagons which are equipped with a generator for supplying power, cinema and slide projectors, a public address system, tape play-back equipment, a record player, and facilities for setting puppet shows. They also, of course, carry handout material to give to the audiences. One of the advantages of the mobile units is that they can seek out their audiences. They can stop at a market or anywhere they find a suitable gathering. Another attractive feature is the number of different techniques can use to stimulate the audience. Besides the specialist staff who accompany them, the units usually carry the local extension worker to deal with local problems. This has the effect of a very strong follow-up and reinforcement of the local extension worker's teaching. By and large, mobile units are usually as part of campaigns which may be national or local. In 1969 there were approximately 120,500 miles and contacted people. At present, there are twelve Land Rovers in the mobile unit fleet of which ten are operative at any one time.

In Malawi the extension service has a separate Extension Aids Branch which prints leaflets and magazines for farmers. These are then distributed by the extension network which covers the country. The Extension Aids Branch produces the agricultural radio programmes for Malawi in cooperation with the Broadcasting Corporation. Now that there are radios in a large number of villages, these programmes have a very useful purpose and have a large public, if feedback in the form of ten to twelve letters per day is anything to go by. Agricultural programmes, mainly in Chichewa, ran for 181 broadcasting hours in 1969 (Malawi 1971a). The interest of the villagers in the use of radio for agricultural advice was stimulated in the first instance by Radio Listening Clubs. These were groups of interested farmers who listened to government supplied at the appropriate time. The local extension worker acted as coordinator and leader. These coordinators had advance information of the subject matter to be discussed on each programme so that they could be prepared to answer farmers' questions and lead any discussion needed (Malawi n.d.). Now, however, the listening groups has lessened considerably and their use is being phased out.

Mass Method. The term "mass method" refers to the use of mass media which large sections of the population are contacted at one particular time. It is usually no face-to-face contact between the extension worker and farmer as actual contact time. As it is used at present in Malawi, the mass method is an exhortatory and follow-up mechanism. The media used are printed publications and radio and, in the specialist mobile units, films and various sound-mechanisms.

The importance of the group, even today, in the rural areas of Malawi cannot be overemphasised. For any progress to be made in agriculture, or rural development of any kind, group approval is necessary. The truly traditional society with its group consultation and action. It is when erroneous ideas arise and the powers of chiefs and headman that one finds outsiders getting into difficulties.